Ten Boats Home

a counting book



Ten boats sail out in the morning. Every evening, Ana counts them home, while Mama mends the nets.



Most of all, she waits for Grandpa's boat. It is little. It is blue. And it carries a lamp, just like the old lamp on the pier.



Red sail.

One!

Not Grandpa's.



Green sail.

Two!

Not Grandpa's.



Three! Four! Five!

Not one of them is Grandpa's.



Six. Seven. Eight. … Nine.

Not little. Not blue. Not Grandpa's.



The gulls go quiet. Ana waits for ten.



But ten is not a boat.

Ten is fog.



The fog swallows the boats. It swallows the pier.
“Where is Grandpa?” Ana whispers.



Ana looks up at the old lamp. She lifts it from its hook. “Mama! Light it, quick!”



Mama lights it. Click! And out they go, into the fog.



At the very end, Ana holds the lamp up high.
Nothing. Only fog.



So she holds it higher.



Out in the fog, something blinks back. A little light. A little boat. A little blue boat.



Ten!

Little. Blue. Grandpa's.



He lifts Ana up, lamp and all. “Ten boats home,” says Grandpa, “and one little light.”



“Eleven,”

says Ana.



